

Alpha ex Machina Quick Reference

Your turn

1. **Margin, then refresh:** uncommitted funding sources pay Margin; then committed cards become available.
2. **Settle:** pay interest; collect office income and Yield (choose Surplus or a card for Patent Portfolio); from round 4 pay the **dividend** (1, then 1 more every 2 rounds); pay carrying costs or discard the card (the total rounds down).
3. **Refill** to your hand size (5; cards change it; min 2; a CEO in hand counts).
4. **Operate:** add 1 funding source (no immediate Margin); 1 staffing move (hire, replay a fired CEO, or open an office); buy tools; play investments, treaties, covers; run Surprise Inspections; use abilities; discard any cards.
5. **Close:** margin call (keep 1 Margin Credit per 10 Surplus); no hand limit.

Stress testing round after the last turn: in turn order, each company may run 1 Surprise Inspection; then delayed ones and the pile's top card hit every company; no runner. Empty pile: shuffle the used ones. Off your turn, play only Responses and that Inspection. **Setup:** CEO and HQ start on the board; draw 5 cards and redraw them once. Everyone shows 5 random deck cards, keeps their hand secret, then secretly picks 5 of 10 Stress Tests for one shuffled pile. Fixed turn order.

Money

- **Leverage:** commit a funding source for 1; committed cards are available again next turn (on paper, slide them forward); unspent Leverage is lost.
- **Surplus:** your capital. 0 or less $\Rightarrow$ insolvent.
- **Alternate payment:** only when a card says so. Pay the full adjusted Leverage cost in Surplus, one for one; keep 1. Normal timing still applies. Cameron commits to allow this for one card.
- **Margin:** uncommitted sources pay before refreshing. Insurance base: printed exposures minus 2 (minimum 1); Financials, including Funding Agreement Notes: 0. Add bonuses. Auto-commit: lowest Margin first.
- **Hire:** pay Leverage. **Poach** (only cards that say so): Hire cost + 2 Surplus; not a staffing move; the poached employee gains Non-compete and arrives committed (gardening leave).
- **Price:** pay Leverage to buy a tool. Not a talent move; one of each; never poached or fired. Its exposures count like a funding source's.
- **Liquidate** any time: Sale value as Leverage or Surplus. Meme Stock waits until your next turn, even for forced sales.
- **Fire Sale:** during a Stress Test, after a sale by a company under 10 Surplus, everyone under 15 sells that investment for half its Sale value, rounded down.
- **Long vol:** when a Volatility Stress Test hits you, each VIX Calls or Long Straddle gains 10% of the table's loss.

Running a Stress Test

1. **Surprise Inspection:** pay its Leverage; choose the target.
2. **Response window:** left of the runner first, runner last; from the pile, the first player first. Responses, committed talent, offices, or tools, liquidation. No responses to responses.
3. **Stop:** cancel a Surprise Inspection. Pay extra Leverage to push through only if the Stop names a price. From the pile, a Stop protects only you. Acts of God can't be stopped.
4. **Resolve,** then check insolvency.

Emergency Equity Infusion: if a Bank Run would hit 2+ of your cards, one in the pile hits everyone at once, before the Stress Test in play. **Everything Is Securities Fraud:** when the Stress Test ends, its target loses what Stress Tests have cost it this round, again. **Structured Notes:** after caps, before recoveries.

Financials (banks and funds)

- **Retail Deposits:** Short-Term Rates exposure, except a third of them (rounded down), which have none; a bank run takes half, rounded down, counting Venture Deposits and Evergreen Credit with them.
- **Investor Capital:** Short-Term Equity exposure.
- **Private Credit:** no exposure; carrying cost $1\frac{1}{2}$.
- **Margin Credit:** no exposure; carrying cost 1; margin call at the end of your turn.

- **Loans** (Credit Cards, Mortgage Lending, Prime Brokerage) are investments with a Credit exposure.

Headquarters and offices

HQ starts free on your board, outside the 40 cards, and stays. Pay **Open** in Leverage for a branch; it shares your staffing move. One of each city per company. Offices produce no Leverage, have no carrying cost, and cannot be poached or fired. Close a branch with no refund; never your HQ. **Fully Remote:** HQ only, no other offices. Offices with funding income pay 1 Surplus per 3 matching sources at turn start, rounded down; committed sources count. **Chicago** instead counts your three futures treaties together, including NFT copies. Opening an office does not refresh purchase discounts. Commit prevention is a total across matching clauses.

Drawing and discarding

Stress Tests draw nothing. Discard face up. To draw from an empty deck, shuffle your discard pile into a new deck and keep drawing. Stop only if both piles are empty.

Uncommit: make a different non-funding card you control available again. Executive Assistant and Delegation Dashboard each do this once between the starts of your turns. Ready or replaying them does not restore a spent use.

Who gets hit

Pile: every company · **Each opponent** (not you) · **Target opponent.** While any living company controls **Tail Dependence**, every Surprise Inspection is Systematic (you too) and cannot Escalate.

Loss math

Clause amount $\times$ (exposures – hedges, min 0). **x2** counts twice. **Nat Cat:** Any matches every Nat Cat peril. Fixed exposures (Onion Farms) always count in full. Escalation keeps the same damage.

Quota Share, Side Letter, Catastrophe XoL, and Dynamic Hedging cost 1 Surplus a turn; other halving and loss-cap treaties have no carrying cost.

Protection order: failed Risk Management cards (“Destroyed if”) $\rightarrow$ covers, ignores, flips $\rightarrow$ halving $\rightarrow$ flat reductions $\rightarrow$ swap payments $\rightarrow$ responses, talent, offices, and tools $\rightarrow$ XoL cap $\rightarrow$ recoveries.

Insolvency

Auto-sell liquid investments. Still at 0 or less: out. Too Big to Fail makes a failure cost everyone else 5 Surplus. If its fallout makes every remaining company fail after automatic sales, its controller wins. Qualifying controllers in the same final wave share the win.

Decks and table size

Deck: 40 cards plus 10 different Stress Tests (every Stress Test is Signature). 3 copies of a card; 1 of a **Signature** card; any number of a **Staple** card. **AI:** AI Bubble Bursts destroys it.

2–4 players. Everyone starts with 30 Surplus.

No round limit. Last solvent company wins, or reach 60 Surplus, twice the starting amount. Finish the action or Stress Test, including turn-start settlement and follow-ups, first. Simultaneous qualifiers share the win.

Keywords

Look ahead Scenario Planner or Early Warning System: commit to see the pile's top card. **Act of God** can't be stopped. **Developing Event** stage 1, then a stage a round instead of a new pile card. **Systematic** hits you too. **Escalate** pay 2 more Leverage to hit every opponent instead of one; same damage. **Illiquid** can't be sold. **Non-compete** can't be poached. **CEO** named Signature Talent; fixed for pre-made decks. Starts on the board for free. Never poached. Firing returns it to hand; replay it for its Hire in Leverage and a staffing move. Normal discards apply. **Dark** Stress Tests may charge separately per Dark card on your board and in your discard pile. Hand and deck do not count. The Paper Shredder removes discard evidence.